

Beyond Words

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My sister and I communicate in very different manners; we often focus on and react to different parts in our daily interactions. For example, I use gestures and eye contact to show that I am listening; as for my sister, I know that she is paying attention when she utters nonverbal sounds. When people share with me their worries, I seek solutions to help them; but when I or others are so depressed that we start to clam up, my sister hovers around us, even when no words were ever spoken. The most striking difference, though, is how we express our affection—I often tell others how much I love them and appreciate them; she never says it aloud, yet she draws our family in her sketchbook every day, multiple times a day.

As all sisters do, we had our moments and our fair share of misunderstandings as we grew up. When I was younger, I found it frustrating that I could not understand what she was telling me; I am sure that she felt the same way. I did not know what was on her mind whenever she stared at a wall without seemingly acknowledging me. Some of her facial expressions were very hard for me to read, and sometimes they still are. It really pained me when I told her I love her and never heard back an answer. Still, despite all the differences, I never gave up on wanting to understand her; after all, she is my family. And having lived with her for almost two decades, I know that I have gradually become better at understanding her.

In fact, when I look back, I am surprised how similar we are. We both want others to know that we are actively listening. When we sense sadness in others, we both seek to alleviate their pain. And although she rarely spoke the words aloud, I realized how much she thinks of me when I went through her sketchbook. I still remember that day when she suddenly refused to show me her drawings. I was puzzled and hurt. But later, I found her sketch of me that she'd left outside my room. Then it dawned on me—she did not want to show it to me before finishing it. Now I know that we both always wanted to connect with others with depth, empathy, and love.

The rift in communication with my sister is not really different from those with other people in my daily life. Even with my closest friends, we sometimes misunderstand, argue with, and apologize to each other. When that happens, we have to spell out our thoughts. Then we realize that we think differently, coming from our different perspectives and experiences. We are so close in the way we express ourselves, yet so different.

And such difficulties in communication are inherently human. Everyone goes through their unique life and finds difficulty in interpreting others. Using one's own experience to make judgments is naturally flawed. It is not insurmountable, though, as long as we attempt to see what others see and feel what others feel. Mistakes can be made, but it is a way of fine-tuning our interaction. My sister and I love each other; out of love, we try our best to communicate despite the mistakes—there lies the beauty of our lives together.

These days, when she starts staring at the wall, I know that she wants to go for a walk. When I invite her to go outside, she puts on a huge smile without any words. I know she loves it. We find solace in shared activities, subtle gestures, and the unspoken understanding that comes with being a family. Through these actions and shared moments, we show our love and care for each other. So when I see her drawing our family in her sketchbook, I make sure to tell her, “I love you too.”